5

Any bartender in the Outer Rim who charged three Imperial credits for a draught of Alderaanian ale would quickly find himself with a boot in his face. Here, that amount was a steal. Thus, he'd waste no drop, and tipped the glass back again, wincing at how warmed over the beer had become as he'd sat, waiting. Restless, he nudged his comm, hoping that perhaps he'd missed the notification of a message, but the display screen only showed him the time. Frustrated, weary, he propped an elbow up on the bartop and turned to the feed of shockboxing on the holovid. At the start of the competition, Tull Raine had walked into the ring undefeated, and as another opponent–a droid, this time–seized up and sparked at the land of another blow, it seemed he would leave the same.

The last week had brought Han no luck in securing an alternate source for the circuit board. He'd walked, he'd called, he'd left messages–nadda. Somehow, Esseles was the most populated damn rock in the sector, and as of yet, no one in a reasonable vicinity had a part that would suffice. Exasperated, he'd been planning to leave yesterday, had started to make preparations to take off, but a single dealer had gotten back to him, had said they'd look. He'd decided to linger for one more day. Now, as each minute slipped by, it appeared that inquiry would also bear no fruit. There was an option to fly around to the other side of the planet at Alabar and try there, but that would mean more money lost in docking fees and time. *Time* was precious. He wanted to just be done with the whole damn thing. To leave. Head back to Nar Shaddaa, pick up the payment, hand it over for parts and put in the labor, then back out for another run. Come back, collect, do it again.

He sighed, accepting the inevitable. He'd have to drag himself back to Tomansen's Hull in Silver Quarry. He could still argue down the price–knock off at least a hundred with the usual back-and-forth of haggling–but that still meant paying six hundred. It would hurt, but his hands felt tied.

The bartender, a Pantoran with a shock of white hair, came back again and lazily inquired if the Corellian who'd spent the whole late morning and most of the afternoon slumped at the bar wanted another. Han waved him off, internally telling himself he'd finish his dregs and then haul himself back to Silver Quarry. He swirled the last sip, trying to make himself mesmerized by the dance of sediment in the glass, and instead, only feeling…nothing. Listless, he lowered the glass and turned again to the holovid.

Another competitor stepped out to the ring, a Houk with lacerations across his massive forearms. Lightwhip marks, Han recognized, though not the usual stray marks of a whip used for pleasure. Whoever had tried to wrestle against the Houk with the weapon must have rigged it to churn out an electrical current high above the legal standard. Watching the Houk stare Raine down, Han guessed the Houk's previous opponent had lost. So would the next. Raine himself seemed to know it, too.

The Houk spun in the camera's angle as they turned to talk to someone outside the ring, revealing the back of his jersey. Han studied the endorsement across the large shoulders, recognized the skreev. The laurel. The coin.

Coin.

Han sat up in his chair as a strange electricity sparked through his brain, like tiny, jolting shocks. *He was already here*, one shock said. Another: *might be worth his while to go check the place out, see just how difficult or invasive they might try to be*. The sum, he remembered, squirming with the realization–it'd more than double his pay for this job.

The prospect almost bowled him over. If he went…if he pulled it off…he'd come back swimming in funds. That'd buy him ship parts that weren't junkyard rescues. It'd buy breathing room. Choices.

Another series of realizations sunk him back down. He'd have to run his old ID. He'd not run it through a scanner since Lothal. No, he corrected himself, remembering through blurry memories that he'd left Lothal and ended up at the settlement on Mon Eron. There, he'd

had to flash his ID to get aboard the clunky transport vessel to head out to Hutt Space. No Imperial had seen his name or his badge since then.

He bit his lip, a waver in his chest. They might have wiped his records. After all this fussing and hemming and arguing, he'd go and the damn thing wouldn't work. Hell, maybe the account didn't even exist anymore, maybe the Imps had wiped that clean, too, and pocketed his money. At that idea, his tongue flopped thick in his mouth. It'd be fitting, *real* on brand for them to have done so. To have taken even more from him.

Movement on the holovid briefly stole his attention. The fight had started. Raine was already on the back foot with a broken nose, though still upright. Fists raised. The Houk swung and Raine artfully dodged it, using his smaller size to his advantage as he let the Houk tire himself out.

Another *zing* in his brain, one that solidified something in his chest: *he'd only find out by going*.

He didn't see the Wook upon entering the bay. Didn't look for him, either. If he could slip in and out without another interrogation of their progress, he'd find that preferable. And, he admitted in the back of his head, some part of him didn't want to concede to Chewie that he'd come into a glut of money if he were successful. This bounty was *his*: his hard work, his sweat. It would be nice, a comfort, for him to have a stash of resources that was his alone. No sharing, no communal pot. A back up, in case he needed it, and he wanted to have it without having to defend his desire to have it.

He made for his bunkroom, walking almost on his toes to lessen the sound of his footfalls, then stopped at the threshold. Where had he put it, he questioned, his eyes passing over the space as though he might have left himself a clue. He bit his lip again, trying to recollect, but the memories were hazy. He could barely even remember buying this damn ship, let alone moving his things into it. He'd not thrown it away, though, and he would store it nowhere else, so it must be here.

He opened the built-in cabinet at his bunkside, rifling quickly through the jumbled mess inside. Other IDs, other aliases, other personalities of his clacked together in his rummaging, but despite a hurried shuffling through them, none were his old badge. He opened and checked the safe, peering past the puny stacks of coins at first, then realized he'd not necessarily have a successful transaction at the bank. Frowning, he picked out enough credits to pay for his circuit board. No ID, though, and he shut the safe to sit back on his heels, his tongue toying with a molar as his gaze skimmed the space again.

There, he realized, sure of himself, as he noticed the usually overlooked closet opposite his bunk. He opened the locker, pushing some rarely used clothing items out of the way to reveal an old rucksack hanging off a hook at the back. He pulled it out, unceremoniously uncinching the top opening and peering down into its contents. He was standing in his own light, though, and tried to tip the bag to see, but it flopped in his grip. Grimacing, he buried a hand down into it and clasped a hodgepodge of objects, pulling them out for inspection.

First, a crumbled ticket, his pass onto the ship from Mon Eron, which he flicked onto the floor.

Next, a delicately folded and quite worn slip of flimsy. He stared at it in confusion for a beat, then pinched the seams and pulled the flimsy apart. There, in curvy handwriting, near illegible from time: *Han, I'm sorry, you don't deserve this–*

His hands crumpled the letter before too much memory could rush in. This was an artifact of sentiment, one that he'd once carried out of habit and now, as he looked at wadded in his palm, he realized he'd forgotten he'd ever kept it. For a brief moment, he considered rereading it, then considered chucking it down on the floor, and ended up deciding to drop it back in the bag.

That left the third item: a thick, metal rimmed square, bearing a face that he somehow recognized and yet had difficulty discerning as his own. Beside the image, the raised text of his rank, his designation number, and his name.

Han Solo.

His thumb rubbed over the embossment. His name. *His* name…that thing he'd had to keep hidden his whole youth, the thing he wasn't even sure was all the way his. Shrike had always been cagey about how he knew the boy's name, and young Han had learned quickly to not take the old fuck's word for granted. Some digging in his early teens had revealed a relative, Thracken, but he managed to be an even bigger piece of shit with no answer. After that wasted effort, though, Han had decided to claim the name regardless, some vestige of maybe at some point belonging somewhere. And if not, he'd make it into something. At that, a flicker of memory flashed before him, remembering the strange choke in his throat when his name had been called at graduation. How much it had meant to him that he'd get to just be *him*…and be proud of it.

Lost in his memories, he hadn't heard the Wookiee footsteps behind him, or at least not registered them. He *definitely* noticed when a hand scrunched his scalp and whipped his head back, the other furred hand finding its grip tight around his throat.

[*You're a liar*!]

Having never quite been so compromised before in the claws of a Wookiee, Han wasn't sure what to do. He gulped at air in vain, straining to recapture the breath that escaped him as his hands feebly pried the fingers at his throat. The room spun and sparkled as he struggled, and somehow, a thin strain of consciousness held on. "Liar about what?" he managed, gasping again after he eked the words out.

Chewie snarled, shaking and squeezing Han a bit before answering. [*You know* ***what***. *I can't believe you*!]

With a roar, the Wookiee picked him up by the throat and threw him into the nearby wall. Han flew like a piece of crumbled flimsy, smashing head first into the locker across from his bed and collapsing to the floor, limbs all akimbo. He writhed in a daze, a low moan escaping from deep in his gut.

Chewie loomed over him. [*I've known you were a shit. I didn't know you'd sink this low*.]

The words landed as muffled in Han's ears. All he could think about was the sharp pounding at his head, the persistent tautness at his throat. But his heart beat fast, his body beginning to shake with adrenaline, and somewhere else in his consciousness, he heard the words ordered at him, echoing like they came from far away: *Get up*.

The Wook seemed to have other ideas, for as soon as Han managed to plant a hand down to raise himself, Chewie stretched a foot under the elbow and kicked out. [*No, don't get up! You stay down there*.]

Han writhed, dragging a breath that caused a reflexive cough. Coming wearily onto his side, his hand shakily trailed across his face, followed by an anticipatory check for blood. His hand came back streaked in red. He tried to regroup, but his thoughts came in snowy bursts, static-riddled and slipping apart. He could think enough to remember he'd not overpower the Wook. Even a blaster shot, enraged as he already was, wouldn't be enough.

"Chewie," he appealed in a pant, trying to lift eyes up to the figure still blocking his doorway.

[*After all we've been through. The promises you made. My* ***oath***!] The Wookiee howled again, the noise reverberating through the room, ringing so loud in Han's ears, he reflexively covered his head. [*You've made me* ***complicit****! It's reprehensible*.]

Still on the floor, Han clawed for consciousness, eager to understand the Wookiee's grief. Only in talking him down, reeling him back in, would Han survive this, but he couldn't do that ignorant. Faintly, he reached for meaning, a stulted scramble to decode or work backwards to make such an outburst make sense. The words echoed in his head. Promises. Oath. Complicit.

The realization, when it arrived, overtook him. The girl. He'd told her to come to the ship yesterday. He'd been planning to just leave, to chance it. He'd forgotten. She hadn't. And she saw her window. She'd lied to him, he gathered. That bitch.

Seeing that the Wook had stayed back, fuming, Han propped himself up on his elbow again. "What'd she tell you?!" he croaked.

Again, Chewie loomed, snarling, but made no move forward. [*The truth! Something I expected I get from you–that you'd understand how important this was*!] Chewie spit on him. [*You lied to me. Looked me right in the face and lied to me*!]

Han huffed, then managed to find enough air to shout back. "I did not! The Hutts set me up! I told them I wouldn't run people."

[*I bet you did*.]

"I did! And then I asked again. I asked what she was. Those fucks lied to me."

Chewie roared again, a thundering call that shook into Han's chest. [*Everything in my gut tells me that's a lie! The way I should tear at you! The way you've* ***dishonored*** *me!*]

Han held one hand up while the other helped steady him, and he managed to get his feet under him. "C'mon," he insisted, his voice gravelly and raw. "I wouldn't've."

Those blue eyes glowered, the shaggy brown fur lifted in tufts across his whole body. [*You would. You have before.*] Chewie hovered there, vibrating in anger. [*You knew*.]

"They were vague on purpose!" he yelled back, finally standing up, albeit shakily, as he gripped the wall.

The Wookiee shook his head, refusing to listen, and those giant clawed hands reared up as though to reach for the Corellian again. Han winced in response, a pointless effort against the Wookie's furor. And yet, though the long arms easily could have ensnared him, the fingers contorted as a bloodcurling howl bellowed out from the big chest. In a darting movement, the hands instead snatched an exposed ventilation pipe and wrenched it from the wall in one smooth movement. With another terrifying roar, the Wookie's arms clenched down on the heavy-gauge duranium, and the metal, resistant at first, gave and folded like tin. With a twist and a sharp pull, the pipe snapped in two, and Chewie flung down the pieces at either side of him.

[*I am forbade to let harm to come to you*] the Wookieesnarled, [so *I will curse you instead! You wicked man! May*

you never find peace! May you never find comfort! May your enemies haunt your dreams and cast long shadows over you! May this debt of mine be fast repaid so I do not suffer much longer your accursed company!]

Han held his position, hands still up to block an assault. He faltered but a fleeting second, his brow wrinkling as he struggled to process the scene before him, before rage of his own burst up from his belly. "Well fuck you, too! I never asked you to come find me!"

[*That's right, you didn't! You didn't have to! Honor bound me to make amends. But you wouldn't know anything about that*.]

Han seethed at the insult first before he found his rebuttal. "You should have minded your own damn business. I didn't need you!"

At that, Chewie closed the distance, and though Han would have liked to hold his ground, he found himself unwittingly pressed up against the bulkhead again, the hot breath of the Wookiee making him crane his head away.

[*And where would you be if I had?*] Chewie hissed at him in guttural tones that made Han's chest vibrate. [*In what unmarked grave would you have ended up? In what empty corner of the galaxy would you have been spaced? No, Han, you're right–you're always right–you didn't need me to peel you up from the sleeve you'd drunkenly sobered all over and point your head in a direction besides annihilation*.] Snorting hard enough that Han flinched his face away in reaction, the Wookiee stood full height, though glowering at him still. [*If only I'd left you to your devices*.]

It took Han a beat to gather himself. His gaze flickered up and found the blue eyes of his copilot staring hard at him, and Han shifted under the weight of the glare. He took stock of himself, noting the length of the silence between them. He'd survived, he surmised, at least this trial. That left the other half.

"Where's the girl?" he managed, still unable to match the Wook's gaze. "Is she gone?"

[*Yes*] Chewie snapped, but before Han's stomach could drop any lower in his body, he added, [*She said she'd go back to the theater, but she left her stuff here.*]

The smallest pocket of air passed Han's lips. Not gone, he reassured himself. Not fucked yet. He steadied himself again, shuffled himself on his feet. "She didn't run?"

The Wookiee, weary now, mournful, rumbled softly. [*I told her to. She told me no.*]

Han swallowed. What a mixed bag. "If she takes off, we're screwed."

[*Fine*] Chewie spat. [*At least I'll be able to live with myself.*] The Wookiee looked long at him. [*Get the part. And let's get off of here.*] Without acknowledging Han again, he withdrew.

Han watched the Wook depart, only as the latter disappeared from sight able to take a full breath to collect himself. His hand came up over his chest, feeling how hard his heart hammered under his breastbone, and then he scrambled for the nav. A cascade of emotions finally broke through the levee as he worked the controls– apprehension about where her pin would be; anger at her for spilling the truth; spite for falling for her charming, lilting tone; frustration for the Hutts for sending him at all–and then her location popped up.

The breath caught in his chest as he made sense of the map. The theater, as she'd said. He blinked as he stared at it again, maybe sure that if he looked away, it might move. He zoomed the image in, staring hard at it, and still it remained in its spot. Impulsively, his thumb started a call.

She answered on the second chirp—distant, a little breathless, but bright-toned. "Captain Solo! You made me go back to the ship for nothing," she ribbed.

The playfulness of her tone threw him for a moment. "I have a part to pick up," he blurted out, his mind racing. He wanted her busy. And the sooner he could have eyes on her, the better. "I'm gonna be at the mechanic's within the hour. Meet me there."

She was quiet for a beat. “A mechanic’s shop? This late in the trip?”

He scrambled for an answer. “Last minute thing.”

“Where at?” she questioned, the lilt in her question revealing her skepticism. After his answer, he heard her choke. “Silver Quarry– all the way out there?!”

“Just do it,” he snapped.

Again, a beat of quiet on the other line. “Okay,” she conceded, the word coming out slow. “Which one? Where at?”

“Tomansen’s Hull. In an hour.”

He ended the call with no further niceties. Still swimming in his head, he gaped around, trying to take stock of himself, of what he was doing. Had been doing. At a trickle at his temple, his hand swept at his forehead, and seeing blood, he wiped again with the back of his wrist, then rummaged into a pile of clothes at the floor and pulled something soft to press to his forehead.

The bank, he remembered faintly. He was on his way to the bank.

Still holding the cloth to his head, he searched the floor, hoping to catch the glint of metal. Dazed and too woozy to bend over, he shuffled his feet to push around the mess beneath him, including the duranium pipes. He did multiple passes, scowling and cursing in between attempts, before he found the rectangle wedged against the wall in front of his bunk. He held it close to study again. Yes, still his face. Still his name. Hopefully, still operational.

* * *

He needed to come to Silver Quarry anyway, and he figured the bank location out this way would prove a little less stuffy than any downtown location. At midday, the sector was busier than he anticipated. Busyness could be good, though, if everyone was wrapped up in their own objectives.

He walked the street twice, ostensibly perusing the shops against the pedestrian street. Thus far, no one had paid him any mind as he'd walked–at least no one but the vendor with the cart full of pastries who'd attempted to solicit with a smile and a warm invite. Han had politely declined. As the smell wafted past him again, he reconsidered. If this went well, maybe he'd indulge. They'd not be Lwyll's *ghlahnas*, but they did smell good.

He slowed to a stop at the quiet corner diagonal from a Quith Financial office. Half-leaning against the office building behind him, he folded his arms to scout the location. It, too, was moderately busy, and from what he could see, fully staffed on the inside, including a clearly bored guard that Han only caught glimpses of when the doors swung open. To *go* inside was out of the question–way too much exposure for his taste. But the walk-up kiosk just outside…that would suffice. He had many more options to flee and fewer means by which to be remembered if he needed out of there.

He fiddled with the ID in his hand a few times as he let the courage build up, first in his belly, then down his thighs and into his feet. With an exhale through his nose, he pushed himself off the building and strode sideways toward the kiosk, his eyes half-focused on the terminal ahead of him while his peripheral watched the entrance with the guard. *Casual*, he commanded himself and had practiced a thousand, thousand times before. Casual didn't warrant attention.

The terminal's red interface blinked at him as he approached, recognizing the signal for engagement. "Please. Insert. Identification," the terminal instructed in the halting tone of a man's voice.

Han tightly inhaled one last time before feeding the ID into the blinking slot.

The machine accepted it, then *clicked* and *clacked* multiple times as different scanners inside read the data. Han watched the screen intently, waiting for an error message to pop up.

"Please. Enter. Passcode."

Passcode. *Good*, he reassured himself; he'd passed the first threshold. His lips rubbed together, massaging away apprehension, and then punched in the six digit code: 130743, his old racing ID.

"Confirming." A lag, and then, "Passcode. Verified."

Han did his utmost to rub the smirk off his face. Instead, he shuffled on his feet, his gaze sweeping around him again. On his right, the street was the same–everyone milling around or walking with brusque purpose. The guard still inside, seemingly ignorant to his existence.

And then his gaze swept left, and his stomach fell out. A patrol–three officers and eight stormtroopers–had just turned the corner onto his street maybe seventy meters back. Heads high and weapons at the ready, then were marching forward, eyes focused in front of them. They'd likely pass behind him on their way to…who knows.

His lips pursed. *Bail?* he heard himself ask like a far-off echo in his head. *No*, his gut answered. He was right here already. Things were going smoothly. They'd pass. He'd look stranger and maybe draw more attention if he closed out the transaction. No, he told himself again, turning his attention back to the screen. Finish.

It took his eyes a few beats to make sense of the screen readout ahead of him. It was the transaction log that he made sense of first–maintenance fees that had been paid out of the account each month, all the way back to this time last year, and underneath those, a withdrawal of 300 credits. At sight of the amount, he involuntarily scowled: he could remember making that withdrawal right across from a no-name bar on Mon Eron. He'd been half-crazed. The only thing that had made sense was drink, and lots of it.

Flinching, he forced his gaze across the screen. Eager to read the current balance, he found it boldly perched in the upper right corner. Over 6,000 credits. Still there. Still his.

Without hesitation, he punched the button to initiate a withdrawal. He wouldn't take all of it, he decided. He could afford to lose a few hundred, just so he'd get no warning message about

minimum balances or initiating a request to close the account. That was too complicated. The damn thing could sit there and rack up fees for forever. So long as he got the bulk of it.

"Please. Present. Biomarkers." The screen shifted to small squares in about the shape of a hand while a tiny camera eye appeared from a slot in the wall.

At this, Han pulled back. He'd made it this far before. Still hadn't run his biomarkers on any of the Imperial-adjacent security systems since leaving. It could work, which would be great, and it could trigger an alarm, which would be…not great. The ID had passed muster. That counted for something, didn't it?

Instinctively, he tossed a glance over his left shoulder. The retinue of Imps was just now passing behind him. He shifted his weight around, letting them get all the way on the other side of him, before he turned back to the screen. He huffed the dread out of him. He'd already come all this way.

He placed his left hand on the screen and leaned in toward the camera, letting the laser scan his retina.

"Data. Collected. Running. Confirmation." On the screen manifested an outline of the skreev. The objects in its claws filled up with red while the rest remained blank.

Processing, Han understood. He sighed, long and weary and anticipatorily relieved, maybe even the frayed edges of excited. Six *thousand* credits. He couldn't even decide what he'd do with it first.

Sudden noise over his shoulder stole his attention. The retinue had stopped right in front of the pastry cart. One of the officers was engaging with the cart owner, a back and forth that Han could hear as strained even over the din of the street. The cart owner, seemingly doing his utmost to suppress a scowl, nonetheless answered the officer's questions in clipped, defensive responses. Something about a permit, Han gathered, as the owner gestured to a datapad that the officer took for scrutiny.

In the lull that followed, Han glanced back at his screen. The skreev had barely filled any further.

The barely restrained answers of the cart owner gave way to barking. Escalation, an attempt at maybe embarrassing the patrol to cave. In response, the stormtroopers stood more erect, their feet shuffling them a little closer. And then all attention went to a new person who walked up to the dispute. Maybe another shop owner? Whoever she was, she moved with comfort and authority. Familiarity, too; she touched the cart owner on the arm as she approached before addressing the lead officer. Whatever the officer said in response only incensed the cart owner further, as he shouted over the replies even louder in protest.

At this, more people stopped, watching, their faces a mix of apprehensive and intent and bitter. At order from a second officer, the stormtroopers took position around the cart. The leader officer said something the cart owner vehemently disagreed to, followed by an obscenity Han couldn't make out but read on the lips. This made some of the onlookers move in closer, and the stormtroopers noticed.

His blood ran cold. This tension felt all too familiar. The situation had gotten too big, too visible. The Imperials would do something about it, something showy, if only to save face.

Bail, he heard distantly, and he snapped around to the terminal, scrambling to find the cancellation request. As he pressed it, he heard additional voices behind him, a chorus of heckling.

The screen went gray. "Are. You. Sure. You. Want. To. Cancel?"

"*Yes*, you tin box," he hissed, selecting again the cancellation request.

The screen flickered, and the outline of the skreev popped back up. "Beginning. Cancellation."

"What the *fuck?*" came out of his mouth but didn't reach his ears. It drowned in the crash that came from behind him.

He flinched at the noise, hugging the terminal while he made quick sense of the scene before him. The pastry cart laying on the ground, overturned. A number of people on the street forming a circle, their clamouring voices growing not just louder but more

daring. Goading. The Imperial officer reaching down to her collar–a call for backup–while the stormtroopers secured the perimeter. A civilian stepped into the face of one of the troopers, barking into the faceless white mask and refusing to step back. The cart owner, turned up into a foment now, on a verbal rampage against the officer while the female shop owner still stood between him and the Imperials, her hands up to both of them, now pleading with whoever would listen in an unmistakable bid to calm down.

Then, she fell. Han couldn't make out if she'd been pushed or she tripped or simply lost her balance, but he watched her dip out of his view. And what happened next was a flurry of action, like trying to put spraying water back in the hose. Someone pushed back at the officer in front of the woman. The cart owner leaned over to help the woman, but too tumbled. Pushing ensued. And then a gun went off.

The gunshot snapped the tension. The strained order of the street devolved into a shouting, pushing mass of people. More weapons discharged. The secondary ring of people–the bystanders who'd not been able to pull away–flew in all directions. Some fled, some froze stock still, and a number of them surged forward. In the mix, Han caught a glimpse of uniforms, newcomers–back up–in a blur of blue-gray.

It took conscious effort to pull his attention away from the chaos in front of him–increasingly *near* him–and critique the terminal. He expected to find his ID already ejected with a faux-friendly message thanking him for doing business with Quith Financial. Instead, he found the screen the same, the loading image only half-filled.

"Come on, you piece of shit!" he growled. Incensed, he skimmed the surface of the terminal with eyes and fingertips, feeling for the edges of the reader. He'd rip the fucking thing open if he had to in order to get the damn ID.

He caught the coming mass of people in his peripheral vision only soon enough to realize they were falling into him as it happened. He got a shoulder into his back first, then lost his footing on the

second impact and the ground came up hard and fast. He hit it palms-down with enough force that his teeth vibrated.

The weight pressed down on him, pinning him, while elbows and knees prodded and jabbed. Han kept his chin down, cognizant of protecting his head both from above and below while his elbows worked to find a steady hold beneath him. The mass above him squirmed, twisting him around with it. A hand clawed at his face. He turned his head away, got an arm under himself again, then his shoulder screamed at the weight. He pushed through it. And then something hard needled against his hip, cold and metal and flailing under the pressure from above.

His decision was immediate and unthinking. His hand fished through the twist of limbs and flesh, found the fingers gripping the pistol and pried the trigger finger back, wresting the weapon free. He secured it in his own grasp, and at the same time, the weight lifted off of him and light returned. He scrambled his feet underneath him and jumped up, or tried to. He faltered on something under his feet–realizing, only as he corrected his foot placement, that it had been someone's wrist–and leaned into the building with one arm while he straightened himself. He gulped down fresh air, the surge of adrenaline, and surveyed the space again. Before him was a tangle of bodies on the ground: an Imperial woman a pace away writhing while holding her side, an Esselian not far off who splayed too awkward to be alive.

A person grappled at him again. Han staggered on his feet, then pushed the person back. He expected them to tumble down, like the push had been error or gravity, but instead the man found his footing again, placing his weight on the backfoot, his attention fixated before him.

Han gawked, confused. The man had hardened eyes, sure with a deep conviction of his hatred for the person standing before him. Bars at the lapel of his blue-gray read Private First Class, if Han remembered correctly. *Why?* he questioned distantly, then realized how he looked: a gash at his forehead and a gun in his hand.

Shooting the Imp was trouble he didn't want. Couldn't afford. Without deliberating, he tossed the pistol over the private's shoulder. The man twisted to watch the weapon sail through the air. Just as he turned back to leap at Han, now unarmed, the private met a fist to his face. Han landed one blow across the jaw, then another down onto the shoulder, and though the man tried to grapple at Han's legs, the latter managed to dart and struggle out of the embrace. As soon as he felt solid pavement under his toes, his feet found a rhythm, driving him away in as much of a switchback pattern as he could muster down the closing wall of Esselians and Imps.

Only once the noise had fallen back into the cityscape did he think about slowing down. Finding a break in the street that opened to a deadend alley, he cut the corner close, only his hands bracing at the building's edge keeping him from clipping his face on the stone. His boots slapped at the pavement as he came to an abrupt stop, a heaving pant overtaking him that quickly morphed into a stitch in his side. He bent into it with a wince, forcing down gulping breaths, cursing himself for falling out of habit with his cardio. At a sensation of trickling at his forehead, he wiped it away, checking the back of his hand. Mostly sweat, yes, but a smear of blood. His head wound must have reopened, either from the fall or the running.

He hunched over, hands at his knees, committed to finding his breath. Unbidden, images flickered past his eyes–the Esselian man laying out, head cocked too far to the side. His eyes had been open, Han could see now…a haunting, empty glaze. And in the memory he could pick out more figures, most of them not the white uniform of the stormtroopers or the blue-gray of the officers but the full palette of color enjoyed by the locals. A riot of color laid across the white limestone street. The woman who had tried to intercede…he wondered if she was one of the dead.

All of it had happened so fast, and none of it needed to.

He exhaled sharply, refusing to dwell. He got away, he grasped. Lived, relatively unscathed. At the reminder, he stood tall, swiped across his forehead again and checked. Less blood–good. His

nose had run, and he cleared the sweat and snot from his upper lip and wiped his hand at his hip.

His heartbeat finally slowed, and with that evenness, his full senses returned. He'd made it out alive, he reiterated to himself, firmer this time. He huffed–almost smiled–at the thought, and only then was able to remember what had preceded the turmoil. The visual of standing before the terminal played in his mind's eye.

His chest sank. All that money, *right there*. His for the taking.

He hovered in a sunken, listless grief for a beat, suddenly too sapped of energy to do anything else. His mouth twisted. It had almost worked. Maybe it could almost work again? And then what hadn't registered to him in the alley or while he ran or once the violence had erupted was what he didn't have on his person.

A vibration of panic shook through him, and he ran hands over himself to check his pockets, hoping that in some blind, unthinking instinct he'd grabbed the ID and maybe just didn't remember doing it. Having checked once, he checked again, digging down into pockets he never, ever used, just in case.

Halfway through a third inspection, he abruptly stopped, and a chill gripped him. No, he didn't have the ID, and that was royally inconvenient, but even more importantly–his face. His name. His biomarkers, pulled from the scan the machine had run before the crowd tumbled over the curb. All that data now sat fresh, *confirmed*, in an Imperial bank terminal–put him in the middle of what had happened, in the middle of whatever they were going to find when they went back to pick through that scene, and they *would* go back, because a riot had kicked up and that meant they'd be hunting for as many scapegoats as possible to hold responsible. It might not matter that he hadn't discharged the weapon.

Fuck.

He needed to move. He checked the street with a quick peek before he glided back into the low traffic, checking the clock on his nav to give him something natural to do as much as he did want to know

the time. He'd said an hour, and he was already over that timeline. He figured he had a few more hours, at most a day, before shit really went sideways; investigators wouldn't dawdle to start nailing people to the wall.

He turned at a corner, each step bringing him closer to the mechanic's. To the fucking part for his fucking ship. Though his deep breaths should have evaporated it out of him, Han could feel vitriol concentrating in his veins, a hot coal in his chest. And his brain kept looping back over the same sentiment, stoking it further: fuck this place. He needed off here ASAP–out of Calamar and off Esseles and away from the Darpa Sector–and he'd *never* come back this way again.

The door to Tomansen's Hull swung open and banged on its hinges. Through the opening strode Han, not a lick apologetic, and even a smidge indignant. He anticipated–hoped!–someone would say something to him, or even scornfully judge him, just to give him an excuse to push back. Instead, he found the shop mostly empty again, save for two figures at the counter.

Once his eyes adjusted to the dimness of the interior, he couldn't help a scowl: the clerk he'd bickered with previously had his elbows up on the counter, leaning onto it, in order to get all the closer to the familiar figure with her hips pushed into the front desk.

The girl had turned at the clamor of his entry, though seemed unfazed at the noise. She straightened slightly as he approached, still smiling, haughty, and somewhere through the haze of his agitation he maybe heard her say hello. The expression wiped off her face as he stepped into the light.

"What happened to you?" she breathed, staring at his forehead.

He sneered at her question, at her feigned concern and pretended ignorance. He had words for her, but not now. "It's a funny story," he growled, then swatted at the air. "Move."

Her head inclined at his demand, a sly move to size him up. "That's not very polite, Captain Solo."

His upper lip curled. He had rancor on his tongue, and somewhere at the back of his brain wondered if he had the willpower to curb his impulse to snap at her. The charge had built up already–it had to be released somehow, or he'd burst.

He managed to swallow down his spitefulness, or at least went through the motions of doing it. Still, he couldn't help but glower at her, pointing off into the corner of the shop. "Just let me handle my business by myself," he insisted through gritted teeth.

Her eyes danced over his face, calculating. Graciously, she dipped her head to acquiesce, then slipped away from the desk to disappear somewhere behind him. He watched until she left his periphery.

Han picked his head up to address the clerk and found the man frowning. "Are you ready?" he asked, gruff despite an attempt at tact.

The clerk frowned harder, then let go of an exhale as he turned to his data screen. "It came out in great condition," he started, trying to be charismatic but unable to mask his irritation. "Mechanic said he hadn't seen one in such good condition in some time. The Sorosuubs tend to gunk over easy. We ran diagnostic tests on it; all came out clean."

The clerk turned a screen for Han to inspect. Sure enough, as Han scrolled through, the circuit board appeared in fantastic condition. He grimaced.

"You got a speeder or something to get this back?" the clerk queried.

"Speeder?!"

"Too awkward to carry," the clerk explained.

"Uh, no," Han answered, stilted, then brushed off the idea. "I'll manage."

The clerk's eyes darted up at him, a flicker of disbelief, but said nothing.

"So what's the damage?" Han asked hurriedly, trying to sound casual but hearing the tension in his voice that made him sound flippant. He braced for the answer.

"Boss priced it out according to what else was in the area," the clerk answered, confident. "875."

Han's brain lagged for a second. Surely, he'd misheard, or the guy had misspoke. There was no way–simply no way. "*Eight?!*" he questioned, the strain evident.

"Eight. Seventy-five," the guy repeated.

Anger raised the hair on the back of his neck. Han openly gawked at him, his thoughts a scrambled static. "You've *got* to be kidding me," he finally sputtered out, then added, "You said *seven* when I was here. Seven!"

"I gave you an estimate."

"Well, you're way off!"

The clerk merely shrugged. "Sorry, pal, I don't set prices."

Han's head cocked sharply, a cough of disgust falling out before he could pull himself together. "Come *on*," he pleaded. "You'd charge that much for a used part? For an outdated ship?!"

The man didn't waver. "Like I said, it's in a pretty rare condition. You won't find a piece like that, *because* your ship's so old. And I checked around–no one else around here has this part." The pleasant smile soured: he knew what he had here, and he knew he had Han cornered.

Han shifted his weight around, unable to stop the ragged groan from his chest. "There's got to be some wiggle room." He leaned in, looming. "Surely, we can work something out."

The clerk's face twisted with disdain. "You're not in a position to haggle."

"This is *bullshit*!" Han roared back. "I could build my own from scratch for that kind of money!"

"You're welcome to," the man countered loudly, his brow crossed. "But either take it or leave." At that, the clerk stared hard at him, clearly pressing for a decision.

Again, Han's upper lip curled into a snarl. He could feel the vitriol climbing his esophagus like a ladder, and he didn't have the will or the desire to st–

"Perhaps if you showed Captain Solo the part, he'd understand the price."

The venom halted at the voice at his elbow.

Han craned his neck to take her in, speechless at her interruption. She didn't consider him in return. Instead, her eyes stayed forward. She'd asked in earnest, her tone soft yet suggestive, and the clerk looked jarred by her request. His lips parted in a pant, then his attention switched back to Han, then her again. He mulled it over for a breath before he only barely nodded at the girl and left, though not without flashing Han a vexed glare.

The girl snapped her attention to Han as soon as the clerk was out of earshot. "What are you doing?!" she hissed under her breath.

"What do you mean?!" Han snarled back. "He's stiffing me!"

"Then let's go somewhere else."

"There is nowhere else!"

Those eyes narrowed, the eyelids tapering. "Then he's not stiffing you. If this is your only option, this is the price."

Han, grumbling. "I don't want to pay a decicred over seven hundred, and if we have to fly to a different sect–"

"Absolutely not, Captain Solo," she interjected as she recoiled. "This trip is on *my* timeline. I have a schedule I need to keep and open projects I need to get back to. We cannot spend an extra day or three or who knows how long while you miserly hunt for a price point." She leaned forward, gesturing in the direction the clerk left. "This man wants to sell you this part. There is a middle ground somewhere. Figure it out."

Han had already taken a step back, a futile attempt at putting space between him and that biting mouth, those searing eyes, the whole damn thing, but the derision of her last words made him close with her, a finger raising to her face. "You know what–this matters so damn much to you? You figure it out!"

She squinted. "It's *your* ship."

"No no no, you wanna stick your nose into everything, you wanna tell people how things should be done, *you* figure it out!" With a heel turn, his feet moved for the door.

"What the hell?" she snipped at his back. He heard her croak in disgust first before adding, "Then how much?"

It'd never come to anything, he'd already decided, so he deigned to answer. Yet somehow, she managed to beat him to the doorway. She caught him by the sleeve of his shirt, forcing him to face her, then met his intense gaze with a resolute glare.

"How *much*?"

"Eight, but seven would be better!" he roared back before swinging his arm free from her grasp and storming through the door. He let it slam shut behind him.

Utterly fucking ridiculous, he fumed, finding space against the building to pace in the blue-purple glow of the signage. *This whole fucking place–this whole fucking system! Fuck that asshole–the smarmy shit. What, I was just supposed to throw down nine* hundred *credits with a fucking smile?! Nine hundred credits for a sunblasted ship that nobody wants!*

And the girl! He stopped walking for a moment as the full force of his aggravation surged through him. The mouth on her–the nerve! Standing there barking at him, directing him around. Who the fuck did she think she was?! She had no idea what the fuck was really going on, and the audacity to talk like she did.

He raged briefly, letting go of a shriek that managed to take at least some of the pressure off. Not all. Not nearly enough.

Overtaken by fury, manic, he sought something–*anything*–that he could take his rage out on. He spotted a garbage can about half his height. Without double checking its contents, he lunged at it and launched the can as hard as he could, sending it skittering and banging down the alleyway as its contents flew out into a snowstorm of debris. The can landed and then rocked at the opening to a gutter.

He panted as the garbage fell at his feet, a bottle ricocheted down the street. He felt little better.

He picked up his pacing again. This was all the Hutts' fault. Fuck them for twisting his arm to come out here, the manipulative, hookah-sucking piles of vrelt shit. And fuck them for emboldening someone like her–they were on their way to getting *exactly* what they wished for and more.

Fuck *all of it*. The 'Suub and Chewie and the girl and the stupid part and the fucking biomarkers and the ID and his lost money and Quith Financial and the souless Imps.

With a huff, he stopped his pacing. He needed to comport himself. He closed his eyes and held his breath until it could come and go in some semblance of moderation. His mouth folded and unfolded as he did it, massaging away the tension in his mouth. Finally, the tide of anger ebbed, not enough to leave him calm, but at least enough that he could think.

He still needed a *fucking* part, he conceded. He'd still need to go back, to explain the whole thing to Chewie, to explain to the Hutts *again* that he couldn't leave yet. The girl–she could be mad. Run her mouth. He'd deal with it.

Restless, he checked the time, then his eyes shot to the doorway. He had no idea how long he'd been out here, but he figured she'd have exited by now. He grimaced at the irritating pull of curiosity for whatever the hell was going on back in the shop, then couldn't decide which he preferred–that her little trickery worked and that he left with the damn part or that it didn't and he could rub it in her face. How glorious that would be: to see her pouted at being denied, vanquished, to have her silly smile and those eyes rejected. He grinned as he imagined the satisfaction.

A few minutes later, when the door did finally open, he spun around to meet her, his hands immediately coming to his hips. His eyebrows arched in anticipation, preparing himself to revel in the disappointment or the anger on her face.

Instead, she emerged unreadable: no shrinking, no scowl, but no big smile, either. "Seven," she informed matter-of-factly.

His face fell. He went slack jawed. Numb, even. "How did you do that?!" he eventually mustered.

"Well, first of all, I was respectful. I don't know why that's so difficult for you." And before he could interject, she added, "And second, I gave him what he wanted."

"He *wanted* my money," Han growled.

She tightly shook her head, dismissing the idea. "Nobody ever wants *just* money."

He reared back, squinting at her. That was the single dumbest thing he'd ever heard. "*Of course* they do."

"You have to think deeper than that," she said, only barely curbing an eyeroll.

He stood erect to look at her squarely. "You flirted with him."

She tutted. "Captain Solo, if you think that a woman having a conversation with you automatically constitutes flirting, then I don't know how you function." She eyed him closely. "Or maybe that makes a lot make sense."

He fumed at her implication. "Well, what then?! You think you're so damn smart."

"I treated him *like a person*. And like we were on the same team. We had the same goal–the part goes from his hands to yours. The negotiation is the *how*."

"I was *doing* that!"

"And unwilling to give ground! You can't work with people like that. You have to have cards to play if you're going to be stubborn, otherwise you're," she paused to search for the word, "*bullying*."

"What do you me–" he started, but the door swung open again.

The clerk emerged, but only part way, propping the door open with his hip. His right hand was free, and his left…Han peered past him to see a small sled. On it sat a delicately crafted piece of metal, conduit, and connections, thin but wide, that would definitely

outstretch his wingspan.

Internally, he griped. He *would* have to call an air taxi. More money wasted.

Only at a hiss of attention from the girl did he realize she was staring at him expectantly, and the clerk was clearly doing his utmost to rigidly look only at her. Yes, Han accepted bitterly: the payment. With an exaggerated huff, he reached into his vest and fingered the credit slips in his inner pocket, able to tell the slips apart by touch. He covertly pulled out the money, then handed it over. It hurt.

"I really appreciate you accommodating us," the girl said, again using that cloying tone, as the clerk counted through the slips. "If ever you're out towards the Outer Rim in about ten months, swing by Kha'art Hadash on Nar Shaddaa and come to my theater. I'll treat you."

"Kha'art…" the clerk breathed, unable to finish the name. "You don't seem like you're from there."

She smirked, her chin cocking playfully. "The Smuggler's Moon has more facets than most people realize." Delicately, she accepted the sled from the clerk, waving a final goodbye.

The warmth dropped as she turned to Han, her affect flat. "I called an airspeeder already." Her hand came up sharply, corrective. "Don't even say anything–*I'll* pay for it."

He balked at her, his breath coughing out in a sharp, sour exhale. "You're pretty pleased with yourself, aren't you?"

"I think a 'thank you' might be appropriate here," she answered, her words heavy with vexation.

He huffed in her face at the assertion, pacing away in a feeble attempt to tamper his temper.

"Captain Solo, I don't understand what your deal is."

This made him whip around. "You don't understand what *my deal* is?!"

"You've done nothing but finger point and yell this whole trip–"

"I didn't want to fucking come on this trip!"

"Okay, but why is that *my* problem? Or *his*?"

He snarled before he could get any words out. "You're somethin' else, you know that? A real piece of work to stand here like you don't know why I'm mad."

She went still, her attention bouncing around him until her eyes flickered wide in understanding. "Your face," she breathed. "Chewie did that."

"Aren't you fucking clever," he whipped back. "I told you to keep your mouth shut!"

She frowned. "I thought you meant to strangers–I didn't know you meant your first mate!"

"You did," he sneered. "You caught that, knowing what you know about Wookiees. *'I'm surprised he came with.'* Probably overheard the conversation in the Spacebarn, too, didn't you?!"

Her chin lifted as her lids lowered. "You two were shouting at each other. There was no missing it–"

"Ha! See!"

"–but I didn't think it my business."

He gestured back behind him in the direction of the Arts District. "But you rattled your fucking mouth off to Chewie first chance you got!" He stared daggers at her. "A liar and two-timer–and a smug one, to boot."

She exhaled sharply first, clearly trying to maintain her cool. "I didn't rattle my mouth off."

"Oh, you didn't?!" he baited, closing the distance between them as his finger pointed to his forehead. "Then how did I get this fucking egg on my head?!"

"I didn't tell him outright," she reiterated, again with a huff. "I didn't know you wouldn't be there this morning, and he made conversation. He asked questions that sounded pretty leading—like he already knew. I was not going to lie to a Wookiee who maybe was trying to catch me in a net." She cooled, her attention focused on his forehead. "Not all of us are protected by a life debt."

"Some fuckin' protection it is," he grumbled as he turned

away, then froze, the hairs on the back of his neck rocketing to a painful standing on end. Slowly, he craned his head around, peering at her over his shoulder. "Who said anything about a life debt?"

He could read in the way she stared at him while she played with her tongue in her mouth that she was choosing her words carefully. When she finally spoke, her voice had a softness he had not heard from her before. "We talked about that, too. About how you and Chewie got entangled."

Instinctively, he braced for whatever cutting follow up remark she had prepared. Surely, she'd not waste such ammunition.

"I get it now," she continued, still gentle. "Why the Hutts insisted it be you."

"They asked me because I'm a great damn pilot!" Han rocketed back.

"They asked because you're an Imperial," she retorted, her eyes flat.

For a moment, he couldn't summon any words. It was as though her declaration had stolen all the air from his lungs. Mouth agape, he struggled to center himself, to find some reserves somewhere of energy, of feeling–*anything*–to launch at her in self-defense. Somehow, he managed to posture enough, to lift his chin and yell back, albeit with a tremor that betrayed him, "I am not!"

"You used to be," she clarified, again in an entreating inflection, "and then you threw it away. They *wanted* it to be you–they wanted to set me up to fail as best as they could, to test my dedication as hard as they could. Who better to free a slave than someone who already has?"

Speechless, he fell onto his back foot. Though he scrambled internally to find something to hurl at her, he choked up slightly as he faintly detected a strange clarity: *this is what it must be like to get gutted*. Disemboweled. The bizarre, illogical sight of one's own viscera, red and slick with blood, so shocking that the pain cannot even register. Something that belonged *inside* had come *out*. It could not go back in. Even if it went back in, it would not be the same. She

knew–she *knew*, and he couldn't undo that, and he couldn't deny it. He panted, desperate to do *something* in the face of annihilation.

His response burst from his chest. "You think you got everybody pinned?! Fuck you! You can take that cocky attitude and shove it!"

At his outburst, she recoiled. Her eyes widened, and the pink flush disappeared from her cheeks. She held his gaze, an attempt at courage behind her eyes. He could see her thinking, then watched her lips part ever so slightly to answer, but closed again, mute, and her jaw clenched instead.

He wagged a finger at her. "Don't even start. I see now how you get your way with the Hutts. You got that pretty veneer and you know how to smile and get what you want. You're not *nice*–you don't give a fuck about anybody! You're no different than me. Hell, you're worse! At least I know what I am and don't pretend to be anything else. All of you, cut from the same fucking cloth!"

Her head dipped at his accusation. She stood still, though he could see the flickering and fluttering of her eyelashes as her eyes darted around in quick thought. Finally, she lifted her chin again, eyes glistening, her throat forcing down a gulp first before she eked out the beginning of a retort. "Captain Solo, I–"

"*No!*" he interrupted, ignoring the whimper in her voice. "Whatever it is, I don't want to fucking hear it!" He closed the distance between them, his finger in her face. "Look, the rest of this trip, you stay the fuck out from underneath my feet, and you keep your fucking comments to yourself. I don't want to see you, I don't want to even *hear* you. You are *cargo* all the way back to Nar Shaddaa."

She gaped at him, not shrinking yet still wide-eyed, her gaze dancing over his face. Slowly, the mouth closed. The brow set. He read her understanding. Acceptance.

From behind her suddenly came the clunking noises of what had to be the air taxi ambling its way through the alley. They both turned back to see a dirty gray-blue airspeeder, perhaps once a nifty little racer but now a rustbox, turn the corner. It approached slowly,

lumbering, before it paused to idle.

Without any additional remark—verbal or otherwise–the girl stepped out from his proximity, the shadow he had cast over her, and carefully walked around him. Briefly, she eyed him again, then started slow footsteps toward the airspeeder. She climbed into the passenger seat.

He exhaled, long and heavy and yet not enough to loosen the tension in his chest. With a scowl, he grabbed hold of the circuit board off the sled, then struggled as he made it into the airspeeder.

The ride back was silent. The only words she spoke were the quietly offered thanks she gave to the driver once they arrived, given alongside the tap of her creditslip. She didn't wait for him to get a grip on the circuit board in order to start the walk back inside nor did she hold the lift for him.

By the time Han made it into the bay, sweating and cursing at the blasted part, he found the space empty.

Chewie, cautiously peering from up the gangplank, came out to join him as soon as the lift door closed. Effortlessly, he took the part into his arms.

Han huffed in exhaustion, sniffled and wiped his nose on the shoulder of his shirt. Breathlessly, he nodded at the ship. "She inside?"

The Wook first eyed him with a long look of disappointment. [*She is. Are we really gonna bring her back*?]

"I ain't forcing her," Han snapped. "She can make her own damn decisions."

Chewie murmured in a mournful rumble. [*It's wrong*.]

"It is what it is."

Silent, the Wook frowned at Han, the air between them thick.

Han chuffed, his head inclining in vexation. "Look, don't act like I'm pleased about any of this. I'm not. But I can't be here, and you can't be here, so can we just bury it so we can get this installed and get off this fucking rock?!"

What followed was…a blur. The work began, each of them

falling into the roles and routines that they'd become toilsomely familiar with. Carefully, they peeled back the different layers of the hyperdrive to expose the existing circuit board. They moved cleanly and swiftly, grumbling clipped responses back and forth to each other about requesting tools, about moving and shifting weight, about loosening wires and unclipping connections. They took no breaks; even as the local sun set and cast the world in the glittering darkness of the not-quite-night of a metropolis, they plodded on, wiping away sweat and ignoring thirst. All things considered, the part installed without issue.

By the time the two of them reentered the cockpit, the faintest sliver of light at the horizon presaged dawn. Each understood their task and performed it briskly. The engine fired up with ease, all systems came on at the ready, and the tower answered them immediately. The ship lifted up off her landing gear and smoothly entered intraplanetary traffic, zigzagging only a few times before a route up and away opened before them.

Han fully engaged his sublight engines once they met the atmo threshold, pushing his ship as hard as she would go as fast as she could, his attention acutely invested in bringing them into the Black. They climbed, Esseles speedily shrinking behind them, until the darkness enveloped them. The nav calculator began chiming at Chewie's prompting as Han took them away from the gravity well of the planet, only cursorily acknowledging another Star Destroyer as they passed into the opening of the hyperspace lane. Finally, as anticipated, the computer spat back its results.

Han's hand mechanically went to the hyperdrive throttle. He pinched it in his fingers and almost pulled down. Instead, his stomach twisted, and he froze there, arm still extended.

His breath had caught in his throat. Unsure, he craned his neck to look his copilot full in the face. He could feel the contortion of his expression, the wrinkles in his brow.

The Wookiee read him. [*What are you waiting for*?]

At the chide, Han forced a swallow, cognizant now of the chiming nav computer counting down his window of opportunity to jump at the coordinates.

It was a solid part, he heard himself. *It installed clean. Do it.*

His hand hovered, the limb feeling like it didn't belong to him, and then, from somewhere, electricity closed his grip. The lever dropped. The small pinpricks of light beyond stretched, elongated, until they twisted and blue-shifted. A portal opened, its dimensions unclear in the swirling light, and the ship's sublight engines went silent as the hyperdrive barreled them forward without complaint.

After a few shallow breaths, it took effort to retract his arm, and Han slowly sat back in his seat. He dazedly removed his gloves and massaged one hand in the other to soothe the tingle in his fingers. His heartbeat settled again, and he managed to swallow over the cord pinching his throat.

He fleetingly glanced at his copilot. "I'm exhausted," he admitted, testing the temperature.

[*You're a lot of things*] Chewie answered, his tone flat.

Han groaned slightly as he recoiled. The Wook would be mad for a while. Fine; he'd not get bent out of shape over it. What was done was done and now…they'd get back, and things would reset. He didn't have to sit here in the discomfort, however.

Without explanation, he left the cockpit for his bunkroom. He didn't flick the light on, and instead sat on the edge of the bed for a moment in the dark, gathering himself. They had eight hours before deceleration. Sleep was never a bad idea, he reasoned, as a fogginess descended over him.

Habit made his hand reach for the ankle of his left boot, but weariness told him not to bother–that he'd only be down for a short nap anyway–and he fell back onto his cot. His arms found the form of his pillow, and he wrapped himself around it, sinking his face into the refuge of the down.